Feeling 50 kilos lighter

We were still involved in the Asia Cup and were due to play Pakistan in Dhaka a couple of days later. I was suddenly feeling a lot more relaxed and was looking forward to batting in what is always a special game for an Indian cricketer, wherever it's played.

When I was interviewed by the former Pakistani captain Ramiz Raja, I suggested to him that I was feeling 50 kilos lighter. In reality it was a little more. The desperation had vanished and it was time to enjoy batting again. Life, it seemed, was finally back to normal. A number of journalists asked me what I was thinking after scoring the 100th ton. I jokingly said to them that I was thinking that I had scored ninety-nine centuries before but everyone seemed to have forgotten about them when trying to give me advice about how to bat. Then someone asked me, 'What were you thinking when you scored your first Test hundred in 1990?' I said to him that I was thinking that there were ninety-nine still to go!

I felt completely different when I went out to open the batting against Pakistan, trying to chase down a formidable score of 329. We lost Gautam Gambhir in the first over, but Virat and I batted freely and put together a 133-run stand at almost seven runs an over. We set up the chase and when I was out for 52, Virat and Rohit finished off the job in style, with Virat ending up with a brilliant 183.

The innings against Pakistan put into perspective how difficult the wait had been and how much pressure I had been under. Despite trying not to think about the 100th hundred, I hadn't been able to escape the tension that had built up. Finally I felt liberated and, more importantly, the media's obsession had been satisfied. Maybe now I would be allowed to concentrate on my batting. For the time being, there was a rare period of calm, and I was desperate to make the most of it.

India in England 2011 – The Pataudi Trophy

1st Test. Lord's. 21–25 July 2011

England 474–8 dec (KP Pietersen 202*, MJ Prior 71, IJL Trott 70; P Kumar 5–106) and 269–6 dec (MJ Prior 103*, SCJ Broad 74; I Sharma 4–59)

India 286 (R Dravid 103, A Mukund 49, **SR Tendulkar 34**; SCJ Broad 4–37, CT Tremlett 3–80) and 261 (SK Raina 78, VVS Laxman 56, **SR**